

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

The chill of the February morning perhaps reminds Lalu Prasad Yadav of the harsh winter, and of harsher realities, as he perches himself humbly in a plastic chair at his wife Rabri Devi's official residence and asks for a mirror. He wants to apply Boroline on his weather-beaten face, perhaps as a shield against the bitter battle ahead. Or maybe it's a mask to hide behind when the going gets tough.

The Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) chief, the erstwhile piper of Bihar who ruled by proxy while his wife occupied the chief minister's chair and the man who had a golden run as the Union railways minister: Lalu has played many roles in the past, many of them simultaneously. Today, when he is preparing to strike and reclaim his state after being ousted during the early winter storm of 2005, he is

The erstwhile piper of Bihar adopts a new strategy before the upcoming Assembly polls, discarding his arrogance and reaching out to his people with new humility



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pitted against historical blunders that he committed when the breeze was behind his back. Though Nitish Kumar has been the solitary stumbling block that has kept him away from Bihar's crown, the chief minister is not the focal point of Lalu's revival strategy. It is himself. And Lalu knows he is fighting against his own image. He desperately needs to expand his support base. For this, he needs to convince himself that he has changed

again into the broadminded Lalu he was in 1995 after returning to power in Bihar. Then he was willing to eschew his belligerence against certain sections of society and thought of carrying everyone with him. And then he lost the opportunity. Today, he seems to have stopped to introspect.

Lalu has learnt his lessons. The trouble is; so has Bihar. Many still remember him as the man who promised a dream and gave a nightmare.

For many, he is still the axis of the revulsion whirl; even his incomparable charm holds an emptiness, symbolising jungle raj. Though he is knocking on doors to win over these very people, they remain shut so far.

That makes it the most important political battle of his life, a make or break prospect which he stares at with his back to the wall. As Bihar readies for the Assembly polls later this year, the odds are stacked against